



READYING FOR TAKE-OFF An artist's rendition of the Noida International Airport

46 | villagers drive in in their gleaming new SUVs, sporting smart watches and iPhones, to seek more compensation for the second phase's land acquisition. The real estate market in the area is witnessing the first signs of a boom. "A large number of multinational companies are showing interest in taking up commercial spaces. Earlier, connectivity used to be a hurdle, but the international airport has paved the way for them," says Deepak Kapoor, Director of property developer Gulshan Group. "Blackstone, Embassy Group, Prestige Estate Projects, DLF, Tata Realty and Godrej Properties among others, have already started work." Gulshan has joined hands with Jaypee Group to build a luxury residential project along the expressway measuring 1.5 million sq. ft.

"Activities that are already underway—through authorities in Noida and Yamuna Expressway—will have a domino effect on the development of the region by attracting investments, creating new jobs, and boosting businesses and other activities," says Niranjani Hiranandani, Co-founder & MD of Hiranandani Group. A decade-long effort by the UP government to position the stretch along the freeway as an industrial hub through YEIDA didn't find many takers. The airport will change that, feels Hiranandani, adding that the state government plans to develop the area as a hub for logistics, IT and data centres.

Manoj Gaur, Chairman & MD of Gaurs Group and Vice President, North, CREDAI National, predicts the region would turn into a manufacturing and transportation hub: "Not only the Noida-Greater Noida region but

areas like Ghaziabad, the entire stretch along the Yamuna Expressway till Agra [will also grow], as the Delhi-Mumbai Expressway will also be connected to the airport. Further, the upcoming film city project and the region's connectivity with Eastern Peripheral Expressway add to this thrust." According to Gaur, the biggest advantage of the project is that the Noida and Yamuna Expressway authorities together have the largest land bank in the country. "The demand for industrial land is now so high in the region that it has led to auctioning of land for industrial purposes, which is very uncommon," he reveals.

"Development of the airport and the infrastructure around it will play a key role in unlocking the real estate potential in the southern micro-markets of Noida and Greater Noida," says Ankita Sood, Head of Research, Housing.com, PropTiger.com & Makaan.com. Sanjay Sethi, CEO of ATS Infrastructure, which has launched projects in the Jewar region, feels the NIA will prove to be a game-changer: "Housing, commercial, retail and hotel development projects are underway as a result of the airport expansion. Higher economic activity will ensure employment opportunities, which should lead to increased demand for residential and commercial properties."

Even as the ground-up airport project rides high on the hopes of unleashing comprehensive development, it will become clear in another two years if those expectations can prepare for take-off. **BT**

@manishpant22, @arndutt